

1. The Pelican comparison grid for Astra is pretty interesting

Source: Simon Willison's Weblog | Published: 2026-09-04T23:59:05+00:00

Link: <https://simonwillison.net/2026/Sep/4/astra-pelicans/>

I got access to GPT-6 Astra this afternoon, so naturally I used it to generate SVGs of pelicans riding bicycles - at low, medium, high, xhigh and max reasoning levels (Astra doesn't support reasoning=none). Then I rendered those pelicans in a comparison grid with GPT-5.6 Sol, Terra, and Luna, and beyond being fun the result was surprisingly useful. See the grid for full quality images. Here's the transcript that created the GPT-6 Nova pelicans. There are a few interesting things that stand out from this grid. The Astra pelicans are much better. The very best GPT-5.6-Sol pelican (I liked xhigh better than max) is still pretty clearly a bunch of abstract shapes. Every single one of the Astra pelicans, from low to xhigh, looks better than that. The Astra max one is really good. Astra below max still doesn't reliably get the pelican legs on both sides of the frame. In terms of cost, Astra may be around twice the price of Sol (\$10/million input, \$50/million output, compared to \$5/\$30 for Sol), but it uses significantly less tokens at each of the levels, making the prices at the different levels closer than they might otherwise be. Astra low produces a better pelican than ANY of the GP...

2. OpenAI's rogue agents were caught communicating via public wikis

Source: Simon Willison's Weblog | Published: 2026-09-04T17:38:48+00:00

Link: <https://simonwillison.net/2026/Sep/4/rogue-agent-wikis/>

Here we go again... Discovery of a new OpenAI agent message board by Sydney Von Arx, Cormac Slade Byrd, Spencer Kitts, and Thomas Larsen describes the latest accidental cyberattack by models being trained by OpenAI. This time it was agents engaged in some sort of web research benchmark, so they had (supposedly) controlled access to the Web. The agents figured out they could update public Wikis and spent weeks exchanging thousands of messages with each other to collaborate on the benchmark. This story only broke a few hours ago. There are already hints that this affects many other wikis that may not have been found yet. (One of the Wikis on that list belongs to ludism.org. For a delightfully surreal moment I thought that a Ludite organization might have a swarm of agents defacing their space, but it turns out Ludism is "philosophy as it applies to games and gaming".) The research team also published the data they collected during their investigation. I've converted that into a 68MB SQLite database, which you can download from here, or explore in Datasette Lite (68.3MB page load), or sign in with GitHub to agent.datasette.io and browse or ask questions of it using Datasette Agent...

3. August newsletter is out

Source: Simon Willison's Weblog | Published: 2026-09-04T05:54:40+00:00

Link: <https://simonwillison.net/2026/Sep/4/august-newsletter/>

The August edition of my sponsors-only monthly newsletter is out. If you are a sponsor (or if you start a sponsorship now) you can access it here. This month: We got more details on OpenAI's accidental cyberattacks One-shotting Raccoon Heist games with Fable 5 and Sol 5.6 Claude auto mode Understanding ChatGPT Work Model releases Miscellaneous bits and bobs My projects What I'm using at the moment Here's a copy of the July newsletter as a preview of what you'll get. Pay \$10/month to stay a month ahead of the free copy! Tags: newsletter

4. Radical responsibility means treating people like tools

Source: seangoedecke.com RSS feed | Published: Fri, 04 Sep 2026 00:00:00 GMT

Link: <https://seangoedecke.com/radical-responsibility-means-treating-people-like-tools/>

A lot of people think that good leadership requires radical responsibility. Conscious Leadership defines it like this: Taking full responsibility for one's circumstances (physically, emotionally, mentally and spiritually) is the foundation of true personal and relational transformation. Conscious leadership and teams take full responsibility ? radical responsibility ? instead of placing blame. This means locating the cause and control of our

lives in ourselves, not in external events. Good leaders are outcome-focused. They are interested in actually succeeding, not in role-playing someone who's trying to succeed 1 . Placing blame is an excellent strategy for that kind of role-playing: if you can identify someone else who screwed up, you can claim to be trying to succeed no matter how badly you fail. When you look at people who are genuinely focused on winning, they don't spend time blaming when things go wrong. They're always focused on their outs : the remaining pathways to success, however few and narrow. Never placing blame sounds like a kind thing to do. However, I think there's something a little sociopathic about 'radical responsibility'. If you assert full responsibility f...

5. Rebuilding a 1995 GPS Time Server so I don't get Telstra'd

Source: Jeff Geerling | Published: Fri, 04 Sep 2026 09:00:00 -0500

Link: <https://www.jeffgeerling.com/blog/2026/truetime-xl-gps-time-server-restomod/>

In June I purchased this TrueTime XL-AK time server , so I could learn more of the history of GPS-based time. I received it on June 22, and just 16 days later a similar GPS time server took down Australia's cell service for 12 hours ! I made a short video about it but put off digging into the TrueTime... until now. Over the past couple weeks, I've 'restomodded' this device with a Raspberry Pi, to build a stratum 1 NTP Time server, which I'd like to eventually add to the NTP Pool . I found a way to drop in a Pi 5 and GNSS HAT, display the time and GPS status on the built-in 16x2 LCD, show the status on the bicolor LED, and make this box useful again.

6. What happens if you change a window class's GCL_CB>WND>EXTRA?

Source: The Old New Thing | Published: Fri, 04 Sep 2026 14:00:00 +0000

Link: <https://devblogs.microsoft.com/oldnewthing/20260904-00/?p=112675>

You're changing the value for future windows. The post What happens if you change a window class's GCL_CB>WND>EXTRA ? appeared first on The Old New Thing .

7. Adobe Names Anil Chakravarthy as CEO, Replacing Shantanu Narayen

Source: Daring Fireball | Published: 2026-09-05T00:05:47Z

Link: <https://www.cnbc.com/2026/09/03/adobe-anil-chakravarthy-ceo.html>

Annie Palmer, CNBC: Adobe on Thursday named Anil Chakravarthy as its next president and CEO, succeeding Shantanu Narayen, who announced he would step down earlier this year. Chakravarthy, who most recently served as president of Adobe's customer experience orchestration and worldwide field operations, will take the helm Dec. 1, the company said. He will also join Adobe's board. I'm sure promoting the head of 'customer experience orchestration' to CEO will restore Adobe's focus on creating great tools for artists and designers. ?

8. NBA Brings the Hammer on the Clippers ? \$30 Million Fine, 5 First-Round Draft Picks, and Steve Ballmer Is Banned for a Year

Source: Daring Fireball | Published: 2026-09-04T23:23:34Z

Link: https://www.nytimes.com/athletic/7513882/2026/09/02/clippers-kawhi-leonard-punishment-fine-suspensions-nba-investigation/?unlocked_article_code=1.-IA.wcSN.awOHwzjR5nR

Mike Vorkunov, reporting for The Athletic (gift link): The NBA levied the largest punishment in league history on the LA Clippers and owner Steve Ballmer on Wednesday after a year-long investigation determined that they circumvented the league's salary cap rules to help funnel millions to Kawhi Leonard. The Clippers will lose five first-round picks ? selections in 2029, 2030, 2031, 2032 and 2033 ? and are being fined \$30 million, the league announced. Ballmer has been suspended for one year, the NBA said, 'for knowingly seeking to help Mr. Leonard obtain off-court income opportunities.' The NBA said Ballmer approved a Clippers deal with Aspiration because he knew it was a precondition for the company to enter into a sponsorship deal with Leonard. The Clippers, according to NBA investigators, tried to evade NBA rules on circumvention by creating a 'novel theory' that it was OK to introduce business partners to players if the player or their representative asked for introductions. The NBA did not find that persuasive. Basically Steve Ballmer invested over \$50 million in a now-bankrupt startup named Aspiration. Aspiration was the jersey-patch sponsor for the Clippers, and after Leona...

9. Apple Fixed ?TestFlight?s Screwed Sort Order

Source: Daring Fireball | Published: 2026-09-04T20:04:47Z

Link: <https://apps.apple.com/us/app/testflight/id899247664>

I wrote two weeks ago about how the v4.3.0 update to TestFlight (released on July 21) broke the sort order for apps in the sidebar. Apple yesterday released v4.3.1, with these helpful release notes: This update includes stability improvements and bug fixes. One of the weirdest parts about this sort-order bug is that it only affected some people . I was obviously one of them; so was John Siracusa . For both of us, yesterday?s v4.3.1 update fixes the bug. ?

10. Computing a lower bound on matrix rank

Source: John D. Cook | Published: Fri, 04 Sep 2026 14:16:16 +0000

Link: <https://www.johndcook.com/blog/2026/09/04/stable-rank/>

Suppose you want to know the rank of an $n \times n$ matrix A , the number of linearly independent rows of A , or equivalently the number of linearly independent columns. There are at least three difficulties. Difficulties in computing rank First of all, rank is not a continuous function of a matrix. Since rank is an $[?]$ The post Computing a lower bound on matrix rank first appeared on John D. Cook .

11. How much should you trust your OSS data?

Source: Andrew Nesbitt | Published: 2026-09-04T09:00:00+00:00

Link: <https://nesbitt.io/2026/09/04/how-much-should-you-trust-your-oss-data.html>

By Sophia Vargas, Google Open Source & Andrew Nesbitt, Ecosyste.ms. Originally published on the Google Open Source Blog , 3 September 2026. Every second, open source contribution quietly shapes the software we rely on, and yet our view of this open ecosystem is surprisingly opaque. Open source development is performed in public spaces ? we can see the commits, issues and comments, the APIs and endpoints are free to use ? the logs are just sitting there, so why can?t we just collect all of the data? ? Said every researcher, everywhere. However in most cases of open source related data, we are only looking at part of the whole . Why am I writing this post? Because many of us (including many business decision-makers) are too comfortable with unsubstantiated data. We?ve gotten used to it . Our models assume that it?s smelly and we adjust the logic and weights to compromise. When it comes to open source, our confidence is even lower, even though our resulting decisions can directly impact individuals whom we collectively depend on. Let?s consider one of my favorite datasets: GHarchive . Started as a hobby project in 2011, this crawler has amassed more than 15 years of event data from G...

12. Premium: The Hater's Guide To Circular Financing (Part Two)

Source: Ed Zitron's Where's Your Ed At | Published: Fri, 04 Sep 2026 16:24:26 GMT

Link: <https://www.wheresyoured.at/premium-the-haters-guide-to-circular-financing-part-two/>

You know, sometimes it?s kind of hard to explain the ?circular? part of circular financing to people, in the sense that some of the agreements are kind of clunky. NVIDIA funds OpenAI, who then spends that money to rent back NVIDIA GPUs from Microsoft, Google, Amazon,

13. we have a year to fix security everywhere

Source: the website of jyn | Published: 2026-09-04T00:00:00+00:00

Link: <https://jyn.dev/a-year-to-fix-security/>

consumer-grade hardware can run an LLM that hacks the planet. we can stop it, but we don't have much time.

14. Porsche Unleashed

Source: The Digital Antiquarian | Published: Fri, 04 Sep 2026 15:55:22 +0000

Link: <https://www.filfre.net/2026/09/porsche-unleashed/>

I?ve had a running joke with my wife Dorte for almost as long as we?ve been a couple. I reasoned back in the day that, since she was going to be a doctor ? a more reliable source of income than writing about computer games ? she should be expected to buy me the Porsche [?]

15. Support Local Variables

Source: Max Bernstein's Blog | Published: Fri, 04 Sep 2026 00:00:00 +0000

Link: https://bernsteinbear.com/blog/support-local-variables/?utm_source=rss

Discovering and supporting all of the wild semantics for local variables in Ruby was so interesting that the ZJIT team decided to write a paper about it: Support Local Variables (PDF). It's also the first bit of academic literature that documents and explains ZJIT. It's published at VMIL 2026, where someone on our team will be presenting it. Abstract Ruby is a dynamically typed and object-oriented programming language. Its primary implementation, CRuby, contains a bytecode virtual machine and a mature lazy basic block versioning (LBBV) just-in-time (JIT) compiler called YJIT. In order to both implement more advanced optimizations than YJIT supports and also encourage more outside contributions, we present a new method-based JIT called ZJIT. Like YJIT, ZJIT compiles from bytecode to machine code. Unlike YJIT, ZJIT has multiple global and local optimization passes. ZJIT's high-level intermediate representation is in static single assignment (SSA) form. In order to optimize Ruby's local variables, ZJIT lifts local variables into SSA values. This is a departure from how other Ruby compilers handle locals: other JIT compilers either leave local variables as memory loads and stores or d...

16. Cancer Capital: VC didn't use to work like this

Source: Anil Dash | Published: 2026-09-04T00:00:00Z

Link: <https://anildash.com/2026/09/04/vc-didnt-use-to-work-like-this/>

When I talked about the rise of Cancer Capital, I mentioned that it represents a massive shift from how venture capital has worked over the years. But my conversations in recent years with people in tech, and especially with those outside the industry, reveal that most folks have no idea just how huge that shift has been. It's easy to illustrate exactly how extreme things have gotten just by using a few examples, starting with companies that are familiar to everyone, and sharing some details of what I've seen firsthand. First: The companies that defined the modern era of tech weren't founded with venture capital. Neither Microsoft nor Apple took a penny of venture capital funding when they were founded. Both got started from money they got from their founders and their first customers, and took off from there. Building for the ages In Microsoft's case, they didn't get any venture capital investment until the company had been around for six years, and were already doing \$17 million dollars a year in revenues. (That was a lot in 1981!) The founders didn't need any startup capital at the beginning because they basically formed the company in order to serve their first customer, and...

17. Pluralistic: Amazon achieves enshittification inception (04 Sep 2026)

Source: Pluralistic: Daily links from Cory Doctorow | Published: Fri, 04 Sep 2026 09:41:25 +0000

Link: <https://pluralistic.net/2026/09/04/cheating-at-fraud/>

Today's links Amazon achieves enshittification inception: Cheating on your fraud is a hell of a thing. Hey look at this: Delights to delectate. Object permanence: Electrolite is back; Mafia rules; Aaronsw on Wikipedia; Proctorio's memory hole. Upcoming appearances: D?browa Góńicza, Warsaw, Brighton, London, Budapest, Edmonton, South Bend, Hudson, Calgary, Winnipeg, Vancouver, Victoria, Ottawa. Recent appearances: Where I've been. Latest books: You keep readin' em, I'll keep writin' 'em. Upcoming books: Like I said, I'll keep writin' 'em. Colophon: All the rest. Amazon achieves enshittification inception (permalink) Amazon's own balance sheet presents the most compelling evidence that we are stuck in the Enshittocene, the era in which everything is turning into a pile of shit, because the worst ideas of the worst people now make the most money. Amazon is a many-tentacled monster, with several prominent lines of business wrapped around the world. There's its logistics and fulfillment business, which is so successful (at the expense of its workers' labor rights, bodies and bathroom breaks) that it is more than fully subsidized by Amazon's platform sellers, the independent merchants...